

POST-1973 DEMOCRATIC MOVEMENTS AND AUTHORITARIAN REASSERTION

Chapter Four

Politics and Government of Thailand

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I

Democratic Awakening and Transitional Politics, 1973–1975

Field Marshal Thanom Kittikachorn's failure to promulgate a permanent constitution intensified criticism of his authoritarian regime and provoked growing demands from students and the wider public for a democratic order.

These tensions culminated in the mass uprising of **14 October 1973**, when students and citizens mobilized to overthrow the military government.

The uprising marked a watershed in Thai political development, bringing an end to the dominance of a centralized authoritarian regime that had long suppressed public participation and initiating a brief but significant era of expanded rights and freedoms.

The political awakening of this period was rooted in the socio-economic transformations initiated under Field Marshal Sarit Thanarat's development policies. Expanded educational opportunities and broader pathways of national development fostered social differentiation and generated a new class of politically conscious students and middle-class citizens.

Yet the democratic opening proved fragile: the period between the October 1973 uprising and the military coup of **October 1977** witnessed only four years of unstable governance, alternating between royal appointments of prime ministers, electoral contests under democratic constitutions, and renewed interventions by the armed forces.

In the immediate aftermath of the uprising, King Bhumibol Adulyadej appointed Sanya Dharmasakti—rector of Thammasat University and member of the Privy Council—as the 12th Prime Minister. His cabinet, composed of civilian, police, and military figures, reflected both continuity and compromise.

The government's central priority was constitutional reform: on 10 December 1973, a National Assembly of 2,347 members was appointed, followed by the royal endorsement of 299 members of a new National Legislative Assembly.

However, the Sanya government was plagued by instability, as cabinet members linked to the former regime undermined public confidence and the Assembly exercised its independence by rejecting key bills. Sanya resigned but was persuaded to continue in office until the promulgation of the 1974 Constitution, which laid the foundation for Thailand's first democratic general election in January 1975.

II

Electoral Politics and Fragile Coalition Governments, 1975–1976



The general election of 26 January 1975 was the first held under the 1974 Constitution, electing 269 members of the House of Representatives for four-year terms. The electoral system combined multi-member constituencies (up to three representatives per constituency) with a population ratio of one MP per 150,000 citizens.

For the first time, all candidates were required to run under party labels, reflecting the intent to strengthen parliamentary politics. Voter turnout reached 9.47 million, or 47.17 percent of the electorate.

A total of 42 parties contested, with 22 ultimately winning seats. The Democrat Party emerged as the largest party with 72 seats, followed by the Social Justice Party (45), Chart Thai Party (28), Agriculture Society Party (19), Social Action Party (18), and National Social Party (16).

Smaller leftist parties such as the Socialist Party of Thailand (15) and the New Force Party (12) also gained representation, alongside a host of minor parties.



As the largest party, the Democrats attempted to form a coalition government with the Agriculture Society Party and the Socialist Front Party. On 6 February 1975, **M.R. Seni Pramoj**, Democrat leader, became Prime Minister.

His government, however, was short-lived: on 6 March 1975 it failed to win parliamentary confidence after presenting its policy statement, exposing the fragility of Thailand's fragmented party system.

A new coalition of 12 parties—led by the Social Justice Party, Chart Thai Party, Social Action Party, and others—emerged to form government. Despite holding only 18 seats, **M.R. Kukrit Pramoj**, leader of the Social Action Party, was nominated and appointed Prime Minister.

Kukrit's multi-party coalition survived less than a year, facing chronic instability and weak parliamentary cohesion. On 12 January 1976, Parliament was dissolved and fresh elections were scheduled.



The **general election of 4 April 1976** elected 279 members, again under the 1974 Constitution's mixed direct election system. Voter turnout declined to 43.99 percent, with 9.07 million ballots cast. Of the 39 parties contesting, 19 won representation.

The **Democrat Party** consolidated its position with 114 seats, followed by the **Chart Thai Party** (56), **Social Action Party** (45), and **Social Justice Party** (28). Smaller groupings, including the Agriculture Society Party, National Social Party, and New Force Party, gained marginal representation, while a cluster of very small parties held only one or two seats each.

These elections revealed the vibrancy but also the fragmentation of Thailand's party system in the mid-1970s. Although the 1974 Constitution institutionalized parliamentary democracy and brought new ideological diversity into the House, the weakness of party cohesion and the prevalence of fragile coalitions left governments vulnerable. The resulting instability paved the way for authoritarian reassertion later in 1976.

III

Authoritarian Reassertion and the October 1976 Coup

Following the April 1976 general election, the **Democrat Party**, which secured the largest share of seats, formed a coalition government with the Chart Thai Party, the Social Justice Party, and the National Social Party.

On 20 April 1976, M.R. **Seni Pramoj**, leader of the Democrats, assumed the premiership. The government, however, soon faced intensifying conflict amidst a polarized political climate.

Leftist student movements mobilized around demands for greater democracy and social justice, while right-wing groups, supported by elements of the military and bureaucracy, mounted increasingly aggressive campaigns to suppress perceived threats to the monarchy and national security.



This confrontation culminated in the 6 October 1976 massacre, when security forces and paramilitary groups violently attacked student protesters at Thammasat University.

On the same day, a military faction calling itself the National Administrative Reform Council (NARC), led by Admiral Sangad Chaloryu, staged a coup d'état, abrogating the 1974 Constitution and imposing martial law.

Political gatherings of more than five people were prohibited, curfews enforced, and legislative power assumed directly by the NARC. Shortly thereafter, the Council appointed Thanin Kraivichien, a staunchly conservative jurist, as Prime Minister.



The 1976 Constitution, promulgated on 22 October 1976, institutionalized this authoritarian order. It vested legislative authority in the NARC, created a Prime Minister's Advisory Council, and empowered the premier under Article 21 to punish acts deemed threatening to the Kingdom, the monarchy, or public order—echoing the emergency powers granted under Sarit's 1959 charter and Thanom's 1972 charter.

Thanin's government, however, quickly proved unsustainable. Its delays in drafting a permanent constitution, severe restrictions on press freedom, and harsh repression drove many students and intellectuals into the jungle to join the Communist Party of Thailand (CPT). By 1977, political turmoil and growing opposition led the same military faction under Sa-ngad to stage another coup on 20 October 1977.



Admiral Sa-ngad's group replaced Thanin with General Kriangsak Chomanan, who assumed the premiership under the 1977 Administrative Charter.

This charter established a National Legislative Assembly, a Constitution Drafting Assembly, and a National Policy Council that ranked above both the legislature and the Cabinet, reinforcing the dominance of the military-bureaucratic nexus.

Kriangsak's government lasted just over a year, culminating in the promulgation of the 1978 Constitution of the Kingdom of Thailand on 21 December 1978, which restored provisions for parliamentary elections. A new general election was scheduled for 22 April 1979, closing one of the most turbulent chapters in Thailand's post-1973 political history and underscoring the cyclical contest between democratic aspiration and authoritarian reassertion.



Recommended Further Readings

- Kongkirati, Prajak. "Counter-movements in democratic transition: Thai right-wing movements after the 1973 popular uprising." *Asian Review* 19.1 (2006): 101-134.
- Lertchoosakul, Kanokrat. *The rise of the Octobrists in contemporary Thailand: Power and conflict among former left-wing student activists in Thai politics*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Southeast Asia Studies, 2016.
- Tongdhamachart, K. (1979). The April 1979 Elections and Post-Election Politics in Thailand. *Contemporary Southeast Asia*, 1(3), 211-231.
- Zimmerman, Robert F. "Student" Revolution" in Thailand: The End of the Thai Bureaucratic Polity?." *Asian Survey* 14.6 (1974): 509-529.